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Internship Reflections

Unlike some of my classmates, I did not intern this past summer. However, this internship reflection essay aims to build on my previous EMPAC analysis of Saie Beauty, a modern beauty brand known for its “skincare-first” approach and commitment to sustainability (Saie Beauty, n.d.). The EMPAC analysis provided a structured approach to evaluating the beauty brand, delving deeper into the company's Dew Blush, its competitors, and its strengths and weaknesses. While the analysis offered valuable insights into Saie’s external strategies, there are still important questions I would have wanted to ask Saie Beauty across each dimension of the EMPAC framework if I had interned there.

Through my research, I discovered important information about the company. Saie stands out from its competitors, such as ILIA Beauty, Sephora, and Amazon, by emphasizing quality over quantity, offering a curated assortment of blush shades, and focusing on its philosophy, “less is more” (Saie Beauty, n.d.). The brand makes up for its lack of physical stores by offering unique tools for its consumers, such as shade-matching quizzes (Saie Beauty, n.d.).

However, while my external research revealed many insights, plenty of details are only available internally. For example, as an outsider, I could only guess what tools Saie’s marketing team may use to track their analytics and metrics for their campaigns, or internal meetings they must have had that shaped their unique return policy. This specific knowledge and these facts would only be known if I were an intern at Saie Beauty. This essay will focus on the questions I

would ask to better understand how Saie operates, makes decisions, and builds its creative strategies.

EMPAC Questions

Entertainment

The first dimension of the EMPAC framework is Entertainment, which considers how a brand engages with its customers. My research showed that Saie uses shade-matching quizzes, influencer content, and diverse swatches, but I would like to learn more about the decision-making behind these processes (Saie Beauty, n.d.). For example, I would like to know the process of how Saie chooses influencers to work with and the guidelines that shape those partnerships. What specific key performance indicators (KPI's) Saie finds important to track and why? Another important question I would have found out interning there would be the specific tools Saie uses to track metrics and evaluate return on investment when it comes to influencer partnerships. Lastly, I would like to ask if there are any plans for virtual try-on tools for its makeup products, like its Dew blush, as this is something that might be important to customers when wanting to purchase a product online.

Matching

Another dimension of the EMPAC framework is Matching, which helps customers find the perfect product for what they are looking for. Saie already uses great tools on their website; however, as an intern, I would have had the opportunity to understand and learn more about the decision-making behind these tools and the current projects they are working on. Some questions that I am interested in learning more about would be: what types of data does Saie rely on to refine its shade ranges and ensure they are inclusive? How does the company choose models to

feature on its website, and does customer feedback play a key role in these decisions? Lastly, I am curious to know if Saie tracks to see if its matching tools help reduce product mismatches? Ultimately, understanding these processes would provide valuable insights into how Saie incorporates inclusivity and customer satisfaction into its decision-making process.

Price and Promotions

The price and promotions dimension of the EMPAC framework examines how Saie positions its products and how it encourages promotions, discounts, or incentives. From my research, I learned that Saie prices its dew blush line at \$26, positioning itself as an accessible brand while still offering clean ingredients for its customers (Saie Beauty, n.d.). In addition, in my EMPAC analysis, I discovered that promotions are rare; however, the brand did offer a 20% discount during May of 2025 and also offers \$10 off your next \$50 order (Saie Beauty, n.d.). If I had the opportunity to intern, I would like to understand how the pricing and promotional decisions are made and why they choose to offer a 20% discount during May, and why they strategically only give \$10 off a \$50 order. For example, how does Saie decide when to run promotions? In addition, I would also like to understand how the company decided on how to create its loyalty program. These questions are important for me to understand how decisions are being made when it comes to pricing its products.

Assortment

The assortment dimension considers the range of products that a brand offers and how to expand them. Saie carries a curated assortment of eleven Dew Blush shades, emphasizing minimalist beauty (Saie Beauty, n.d.). This raises the question: what does the internal process look like when Saie wants to create a new shade in its Dew Blush? I would like to understand if

this information is solely based on consumer research and feedback, or if this is a creative director's idea, or both. In addition, I would like to understand how Saie prioritizes between expanding an existing shade range or developing an entirely new product. These questions would reveal Saie's strategy for product innovation and adapting to customer demand long-term.

Convenience

Lastly, the final EMPAC dimension is convenience, which focuses on how easily consumers can purchase, receive, and return the product. Saie has created a strong e-commerce website and seamless online shopping experience for its customers. The company gives features like free shipping on qualifying orders and expedited delivery options, but a very unusual feature is its return policy. Unlike beauty brands like Sephora, which allow you to return your product in-store seamlessly after use, Saie instead provides customers with a 50% refund and a 25% discount on their next purchase within 30 days (Saie Beauty, n.d.). If I were an intern at Saie, I would like to understand the reasoning behind its unique return method. Do customers get upset regarding this return method, or is it something they prefer? Does this policy come from sustainability goals or financial gain? Furthermore, I would like to know more about the internal goals for delivery time and how quickly Saie aims to get products to customers. Lastly, I would like to know how Saie evaluates and chooses shipping partners. Do these companies prioritize speed, cost, and eco-friendliness in shipping? These insights will allow me to understand how Saie prioritizes its customer convenience while also focusing on its overall brand value of sustainability.

Conclusion

Overall, if I had the opportunity to intern at Saie this summer, I would have been able to ask these questions directly and gain valuable insight into the company. These answered questions would provide me with a deeper understanding of how Saie operates internally, how decisions are made, and how strategies are developed, whether by listening to customer feedback or by pursuing ideas that the company believes are unique. Reflecting on these questions has helped me think more critically about the balance between consumer needs and overall brand identity. In the future, this practice will allow me to approach marketing roles with a greater sense of curiosity, allowing me the confidence to ask these questions in coffee chats or with my managers, and, overall, gain a stronger understanding of how brands create value for their customers.

References

Saie Beauty. (n.d.). *Saie's official website*. Retrieved May 2025, from <https://saiehello.com/>

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